supporting the broader national goal of establishing safe and standardized UAM operations.

Although Skyward's commercial service was discontinued, the technological and regulatory foundations laid by its initiatives continue to influence current drone communication projects in government, industry, and telecom sectors. The program demonstrated that 5G connectivity can serve as a backbone for large-scale autonomous drone ecosystems, enabling fleets to operate collaboratively, safely, and with high information fidelity.

Skyward's role is best understood as a transitional milestone in the progression toward fully integrated urban air mobility, illustrating how telecommunications infrastructure, aviation standards, and industry partnerships must align to unlock the full potential of connected UAV systems in the United States.

Figure 9.10 illustrates Verizon Skyward's use of 5G cellular networks to support real-time drone operations in the United States. The drone communicates with ground control through a high-bandwidth, low-latency 5G network tower, enabling continuous telemetry streaming, live video transmission, and beyond visual line of sight (BVLOS) command and control. This architecture demonstrates how telecommunications infrastructure forms a foundational layer for scalable, safe, and integrated UAV missions in industrial, emergency response, and urban mobility applications.